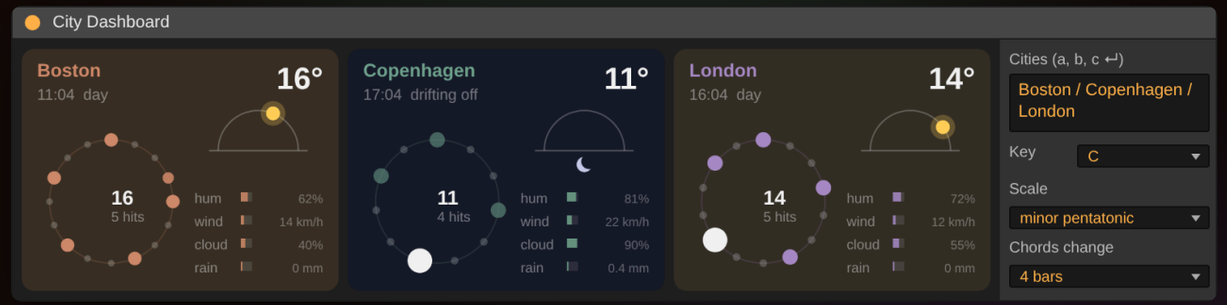
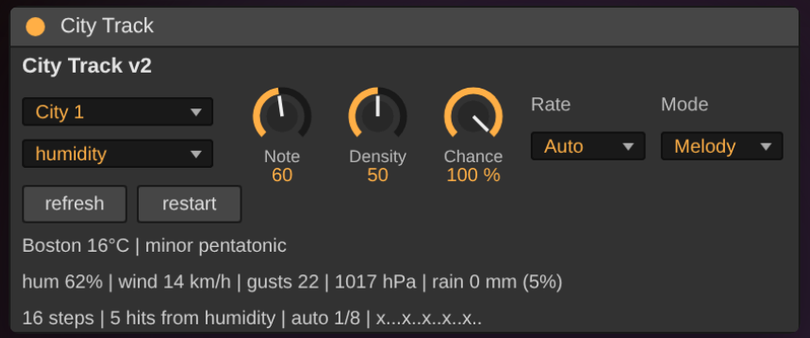
FORREST JAMES · MAX FOR LIVE · V2

THREE CITIES

for Ableton Live

Two devices that play the live weather of three places as rhythm and melody. Quick start, then everything you can do with them.





The two devices, drawn from their patches. Colours in your copy of Live may differ a little.

UP AND PLAYING IN FOUR STEPS

1 Save the folder

```
▸ Three Cities v2
  City Track.amxd
  City Dashboard.amxd
  city_track.js
  city_dashboard.js
  city_weather.js
```

Unzip it and keep it whole, with the .js files next to the two devices. Your User Library is a good home.

2 Add the dashboard



Drag City Dashboard onto any track. An empty audio track or the master is fine. It is where you choose the cities.

3 Add three tracks



Make three MIDI tracks, each with an instrument. Drag City Track onto each, before the instrument. Set City to 1, 2 and 3.

4 Press play



Each track plays its city's weather. Turn `Mode` to `Melody` to hear the shared key and chords. The weather refreshes every 10 minutes.

YOU NEED Ableton Live 12 with Max for Live, and an internet connection. The weather comes from Open-Meteo.

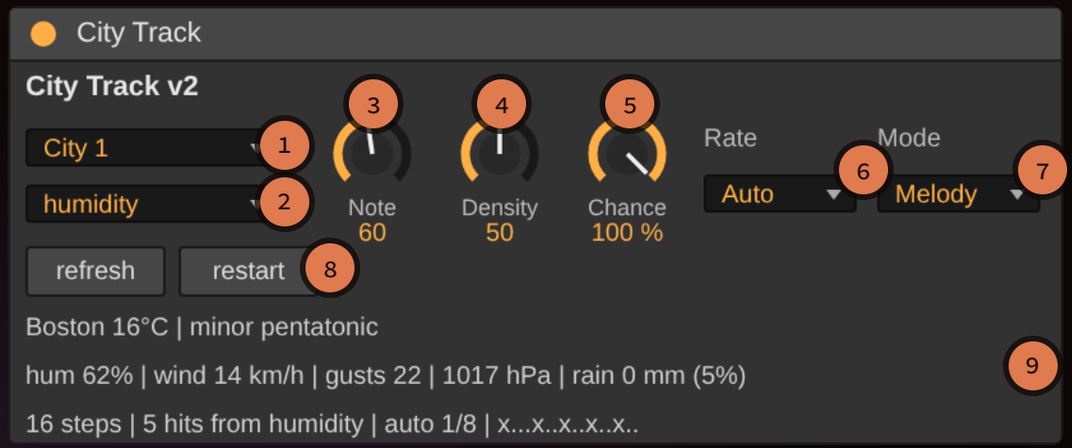
TIP Once it works, use Freeze Device in each device's Max editor. The scripts then travel inside the device and you can move it anywhere.

WHAT EACH ONE DOES

City Track

MIDI EFFECT · ONE PER MIDI TRACK

Plays one city. Its temperature sets the length of a rhythm, and its weather decides which steps sound. Put one on each track.



1 City: which of the three cities this track plays.

2 Hits from: humidity, wind, cloud or rain.

3 Note: the base pitch, as a MIDI note.

4 Density: how many of the possible hits play.

5 Chance: the odds that a hit sounds.

6 Rate: step speed. Auto follows air pressure.

7 Mode: Rhythm is one note. Melody walks the scale.

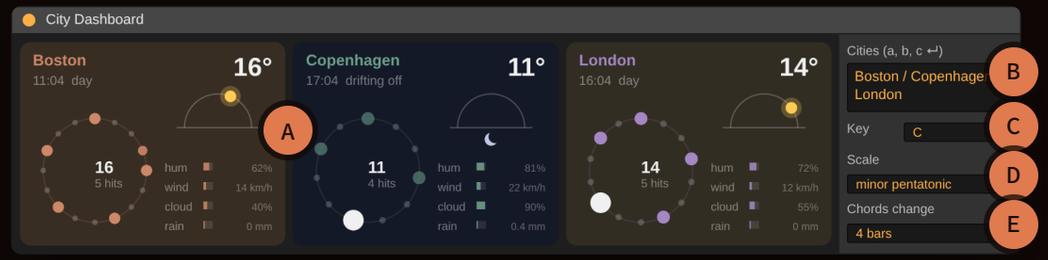
8 refresh / restart: fetch weather now, or go back to step 1.

9 Display: the city, the weather, and the pattern as x (hit) and . (rest).

City Dashboard

AUDIO EFFECT · ONE PER SET

The picture of all three cities, and the place where you choose them. Every City Track follows what you set here.



A Each panel: local time, temperature, the sun's position, the rhythm as a ring with a live playhead, and the weather bars.

B Cities: type any three places, separated by slashes or commas, then press Return.

C Key and D Scale: the shared key. 17 scales, from minor pentatonic to ryukyu.

E Chords change: every 4, 8, 16 or 32 bars, or Drone to stay on the home chord.

HOW IT WORKS

WEATHER BECOMES MUSIC



One ring is one city. Filled dots are hits. Small dots are rests.

MELODY MODE Each hit walks the shared scale and leans onto a chord progression that follows Live's song position. All three tracks play in the same key over the same chords. Calm air takes small steps, wind makes the line leap, and humid air repeats notes. The three cities also take turns being up front, a minute or two each.

TEMPERATURE → STEPS

16°C is a 16-step pattern. Below zero it uses the number without the minus sign, and drops an octave.

THE WEATHER → HITS

Hits from picks humidity, wind, cloud or rain. It sets how many notes are spread across the steps. Density scales it.

THE SUN → CC1 AND CC74

The sun's arc goes out as mod wheel (CC1). CC74 carries brightness: the sun, and less when the city is asleep.

NIGHT → SLEEP

After sunset a city drifts off over two hours. More rests, softer notes, and half speed in deep sleep. It stirs before sunrise.

AIR PRESSURE → PACE

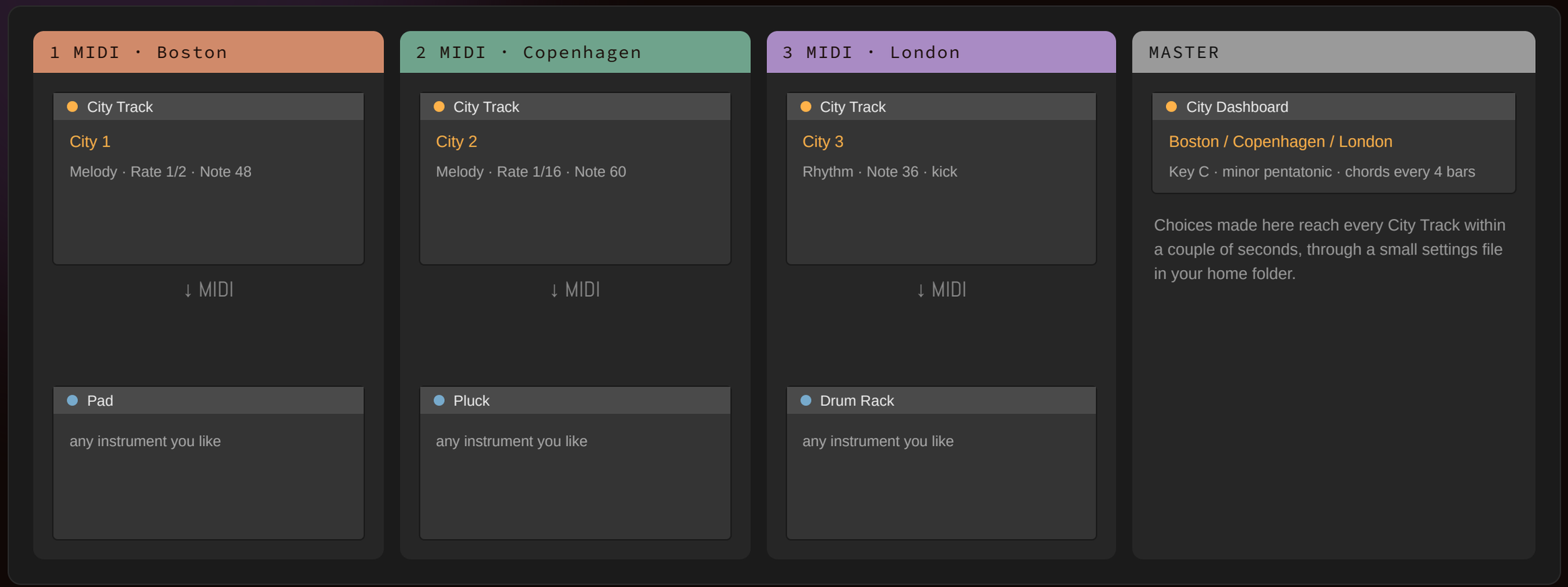
With Rate on Auto, settled high pressure plays in 1/8 notes. Otherwise 1/16.

RAIN AND GUSTS → TEXTURE

The chance of rain thins the line, up to a third resting. Unsettled weather adds quick doubles and little runs.

IN ABLETON LIVE

WHAT YOUR SET LOOKS LIKE



ONE DASHBOARD
Anywhere in the set. It does not make sound.

THREE CITY TRACKS
One per MIDI track, before the instrument. Pick City 1, 2 and 3.

YOUR SOUNDS
Sounds, reverb, delay and recording are your own instruments, effects and Live.

SIX WAYS TO PLAY WITH IT

1 · A SLOW PAD



Set `Mode` to Melody, `Rate` to 1/2 or 1 bar, and `Note` low, around 48. Put it on a soft pad and lower `Density`.

2 · A PLUCKED LINE



Melody mode, `Rate` 1/16, `Note` 60 or higher. A high line leans onto the chord more often. Bring `Chance` down for gaps.

3 · WEATHER DRUMS



Use Rhythm mode into a Drum Rack. It plays one note, the weather's rhythm. On a default rack, Note 36, 38 and 42 are kick, snare and hat.

4 · LET THE SUN MOVE A SOUND



The sun goes out as mod wheel (CC1) and brightness (CC74). Use any instrument or plug-in that listens to them, so each city opens up in daylight.

5 · YOUR OWN CITIES

New York / Tokyo / Lima

Type any three places into the Cities box on the dashboard and press Return. Use the places you have lived, or the ones you dream of.

6 · CHANGE THE MOOD

`dorian` `lydian` `yo` `whole tone` `Drone`

Pick a Key and Scale on the dashboard. Set `Chords change` to 4, 8, 16 or 32 bars, or Drone to stay on one chord.

A STARTER SET

THREE TRACKS TO BEGIN WITH

TRACK	CITY	MODE	RATE	NOTE	INTO
1	City 1	Melody	1 bar	48	a soft pad
2	City 2	Melody	1/16	62	a pluck
3	City 3	Rhythm	1/16	36	a Drum Rack, on the kick

THEN CHANGE ONE THING AT A TIME

Pick a new Key and Scale on the dashboard.

Set Chords change to 16 bars, or Drone.

Swap a city for one you love: `Boston / Lisbon / Lagos`

Switch Rate to Auto and let the air pressure set the pace.

Turn Chance down on one track to leave room for the others.

KEEP WHAT YOU LIKE

Menu changes are saved with your Live set. The weather is live, so tomorrow will sound different.

When you hear something you want to keep, record the audio in Live.

WHEN SOMETHING LOOKS OFF

THE DISPLAY TELLS YOU WHAT IS HAPPENING

`waiting for weather`
The first fetch has not finished. Wait a few seconds. If it stays, check your internet and press refresh.

`Couldn't find …`
The place was not recognised. Try the city on its own, or add the country, in the Cities box.

`a city can't be reached`
It keeps its last weather and says when it will try again. Each city gets three tries.

`the devices are not in the browser`
Only the two .amxd files show. The .js files stay hidden. Add the folder under Places, or drag an .amxd onto a track.

`an older set sounds different`
Open it and set Chords change once. It is saved with the set from then on.

EVERY CONTROL

City	City 1, 2 or 3
Hits from	humidity, wind, cloud, rain
Note	MIDI note 0 to 127, starts at 60
Density	0 to 100, how many hits play
Chance	0 to 100, odds a hit sounds
Rate	Auto, 1/32, 1/16, 1/8, 1/4, 1/2, 1 bar
Mode	Rhythm or Melody
refresh	fetch the weather now
restart	back to step 1
Cities	any three places, a / b / c
Key	C to B
Scale	17 scales
Chords change	4, 8, 16, 32 bars or Drone

MIDI OUT Notes, plus CC1 (the sun's arc) and CC74 (brightness).

Weather from Open-Meteo. Made by Forrest James. The web version, where you can also pick your cities and share a link, is at this address.

`threecities.forrestjamesmusic.com`